within the region. Malik says the presence of institutions like the National Institute of Electronics and Information Technology, which has trained more than 700 students, has helped. "We did a skill gap analysis and are now aligning training programmes with industry demands," she says.

Next up is a 5,500-acre industrial zone in Dhuriyapar, among the region's most underdeveloped areas, where land is being acquired across 17 villages. Industries such as Adani Cements have already shown interest, helped by the new rail links and its location near the Purvanchal Expressway. Indeed, both Mishra and Malik stress Gorakhpur's logistical advantages. "We sit at a geographic crossroads, connecting eastern India, Bihar, Nepal and the rest of UP. This benefits local industries and positions Gorakhpur as an alternative to more saturated hubs," points out Mishra.

GIDA is also working to attract sector-specific investments. "We are developing UP's first plastic park, with space for 90 industrial units. Over 70 units have been allotted," says Malik. Beyond the industrial infrastructure, Gorakhpur's urban transformation is also playing a role. With two five-star hotels already functional and two more under construction, the hospitality industry is expanding. State-backed infrastructure and urban projects are also reshaping the city. In FY25, CM Adityanath laid the foundation for projects worth over Rs 3,500 crore, including the Rapti Nagar Expansion Township and Sports City, and the 'new Gorakhpur city'. ■

Takeaways

- **GIDA brought Rs 12,500 crore in investments to Gorakhpur in the past 3 years**
- **1,167 units now operational at industrial corridor, generating 42,000 jobs**

▶ GOA

SAVING THE FROG

A new awareness campaign hopes to get an illicit delicacy—frog's legs—off Goa's restaurant menus

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IN 2020, GOA'S REPUBLIC DAY tableau on Rajpath had a giant green frog strumming a guitar. Back home, though, they often land on a plate. 'Jumping Chicken', they call it, for the benefit of meat lovers indulging in it on the sly. Up the chain from restaurants that serve it are poachers who track frogs when they surface during the rains, their breeding season. The most hunted species are the Indian Bullfrog and the Jerdon's Bullfrog. Both have fleshy hindlegs, the part that's curried or fried.

What the frogs themselves eat is quite crucial. Adults and tadpoles feed on mosquito eggs and larvae, exerting a natural control on vector-borne diseases. Besides, they devour a whole variety of insects deemed farm pests, ensuring lower crop losses. Thus, frog poaching impinges on the ecology, public health, agriculture and food security. It also violates the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972. Frogs are protected species—hunting them can lead you to getting fried in jail for three years.

Goa is now trying to get frog meat off restaurant menus. In May, state forests minister Vishwajit Rane launched a 'Save the Frog' campaign, aiming to protect their monsoon habitats. "The hunters track down the Bullfrog at night by its croak, using torch light to stun them," says a forest official. While it's an age-old practice in many parts of Goa, the rising commercial demand for frog meat has started seriously skewing the numbers.

Frogs, a barometer of ecological health in zones along the Western Ghats, also face threats from urbanisation, deforestation and linear projects like highways. Activist Clinton Vaz says awareness is getting the 'jumping chicken' off menus, but that's only a start. ■



CAUGHT IN THE ACT Smuggled bull frogs seized from a bus in Goa